necessary elements that could sustain long-term growth. There was only that much that the company could have grown when it was not steered by a professional structure, says K.R.S. Jamwal, vice president, strategy, GCC, Tata Sons.

In the urge to grow, several compromises were also made. Consequently, by the time Kerkar left, IHCL was entangled in several controversies that originated from his questionable decisions, as discussed earlier. A scientific approach too was lacking in dealing with the growth of the company.

There was neither a strategic plan nor a corporate structure to guide the company under Kerkar. The growth was, therefore, haphazard and unsustainable. Ratan commented that what was followed was a 'shotgun' approach and 'just taking a lot of properties and saying you are a global brand' was not an optimum growth strategy. He added that many of the new acquisitions were best avoided: 'Nor have the properties been such that they would lend themselves to the exploitation of the brand.'

Pursuant to Kerkar's exit, Ratan focused on transforming IHCL after appointing his trusted lieutenant, R.K. Krishna Kumar, as the MD. Thus began a new phase in IHCL's history. With Krishna Kumar, a veteran credited with extraordinary marketing and branding talents, at the helm, the company began its journey towards professionalism and growth.

Under the new dispensation, the company embarked on 'sweeping changes', wrote the *Financial Times*. What was planned was a broader 'restructuring' of the company. It entailed the transformation of the enterprise through a three-pillar strategy of expansion, branding and marketing.

The expansion segment had both a domestic and an international component. The former aimed at strengthening the company to catch the winds of the rising potential of internal tourism in India. It was also motivated by the need to build on the company's large presence in the country and to counter increasing foreign competition. The international strategy, on the other hand, was crafted to acquire marquee hotel brands as upscale and prestigious as the Taj brand and in the process increase the company's footprint outside India. The strategy was to showcase the uniqueness of Indian hospitality to the outside world through brand Taj.

Paradoxically, the overseas expansion strategy also envisaged the sale of some of the foreign assets. This was necessary to protect the brand's reputation. It was one of the earliest tasks that Ratan undertook. Speaking at